

Case study: UPI/Online payment fraud

One common cybercrime today is UPI/online payment fraud, where attackers trick users into transferring money or sharing sensitive banking details. In a typical case, the victim receives a phone call or message from someone pretending to be a bank official or customer support agent. The scammer creates urgency, saying that the account will be blocked or that a transaction has failed. They then ask the victim to share an OTP or click on a malicious link.

Once the victim shares the OTP or clicks the link, the attacker gains access to their bank account or UPI app. Money is then quickly transferred to multiple accounts, making it difficult to trace. In some cases, victims unknowingly install fake apps that give attackers full access to their phone and personal data.

This type of fraud usually targets students, elderly people, or individuals who are not very aware of digital safety practices. Scammers often use fear, urgency, or greed as psychological tricks.

The consequences can be severe, including financial loss, mental stress, and loss of trust in digital systems. Victims may also struggle to recover the lost money. This highlights the importance of being cautious while using online payment systems and never sharing sensitive information like OTPs or PINs with anyone.

Prevention

To stay safe from cybercrime, especially UPI fraud, it is important to follow simple but effective precautions.

- never share your OTP, PIN, or banking passwords with anyone, even if they claim to be from a bank.
- always verify unknown calls or messages before taking any action.
- avoid clicking on suspicious links or downloading unknown apps.
- enable two-factor authentication for added security.
- use official banking apps only and keep them updated regularly.
- check transaction details carefully before confirming any payment.
- report any suspicious activity immediately to the **National Cyber Crime Portal (cybercrime.gov.in)** or call the **Helpline 1930**.
- always stay aware and educated about common online scams.

Following these steps can significantly reduce the risk of falling victim to cyber fraud.